

agement Information System'. It is one of the first forays into building a system on open source software. The WBPC board uses Linux servers to run their state-wide operation. But the move to the desktop has not been ignored. The WBPC has 110 computers in operation. As of now 12 computers are running on Linux. Once the simputer project is implemented, the operation and processing will be done by the servers, and most client tasks will be restricted to browsers—thus providing an impetus towards cheaper operating systems. Such a project explains just why a large body should make the switch.

Such a change is even more obvious for cash strapped educational institutions. Such programmes are under development in places across India. As of now, three sizeable projects are underway in Chennai, Goa and Kerala. Demo@Schools is a project that has now come under the hood of the Free Software Foundation. It aims at popularising free software to the masses. The project is trying to convince educational institutions to replace their proprietary software formats and provide free software replacements. In a similar manner, Goa and Kerala are seriously considering the adoption of GNU or

Linux based solutions to educational institutions.

Linux: All Talk and no substance?

So far so good, but then, why is Windows the desktop of choice? A simple analysis of our computer market will provide the answer. When a PC is purchased, it is likely to come with Windows preloaded. System Assemblers do this simply because they do not wish to be confused, or confuse customers with multiple choices. Linux is not considered, simply because of user fear. This is one of the main problems of Linux. Since its inception, a lot has been done to make Linux user-friendly. But the problem here is that the end

contrast to this all the versions of Windows have a similar interface. But, there is more to this than meets the eye. According to Trevor, the problem lies in clearing the image of Linux. "Defining a proper Business Model for an Open Source development is a major hurdle. Linux is equally user friendly and application support is available. But the costs required to push this notion around the world are enormous."

The Transition Process...

It is not possible to simply switch from one OS to another. The transition period is one of the most important stages of the entire process. The final decision as to



Deepak Phatak
KReSIT, IIT Bombay

“It’s a chicken and egg story. A mature product such as Tally is available for Windows. There is no reason to switch over because it is doing quite well. The other available packages do not have the functionality that Tally can boast of.”

Why focus on India?

Well we all know that Linux is a sizeable power in the OS market. But, does Linux have a bearing in India? Yes! India is definitely an important global resource in terms of computing. The amount of technical brainpower coupled with the sizeable English speaking populace has made the Indian employee a much sought after worker. Thus it makes sense that the Open Source movement should catch up to India. The movement also gives programmers a chance to demonstrate their own skills independently rather than be forced to follow an organisation.

In India, most software currently being used is pirated. Software sales have suffered due to this. The gaming industry has almost given up on India, due to piracy. Here, Linux has an advantage. It is either free or available for such low prices that the question of piracy doesn't arise. The Indian users' need for cheaper introductory PCs can also be realised by offering a Linux OS pre-loaded.

user is not aware of this fact. Also, the usability of Linux still does not match a Windows OS. With such an aura, would anybody use Linux?

If some heroic soul does make the decision to use Linux, he has to choose between many Linux distributions—Red-Hat, Mandrake, Caldera, etc. It is difficult to make an informed choice of which distribution is best for what scenario. This again makes an organisation think twice about making a switch. Though all the flavours of Linux are quite interoperable, many are concerned about support and compatibility with other systems.

Another problem that comes up is application selection. An organisation may probably have a set of applications, used by employees to perform various tasks. When the switch to Linux is made, applications that do the job just as well as their Windows counterparts need to be procured and deployed. After all of this, you still have to learn the differences in operation commands with Linux, and will have a long way to go before you become a power user.

Since Linux is open source, there are many companies that develop the different variants of Linux available today. In

switch or not to switch is dependant on the success of the transition. During the transition period, one must critically test out the areas in which the system will be used most.

The first thing that must be done is a thorough analysis of the system. The two major roles of Linux as an OS are at the server level and at the desktop level. Linux has already been accepted as a good solution for a server. This is also due to the interoperability between a Linux server and Windows workstations.

But the real challenge is getting Linux to the desktop. While it may not be very difficult to convince a system administrator to switch to Linux, try convincing an accountant, using Tally on his Windows-based machine. The ultimate goal here is to provide the same operating environment at a lesser cost. A non-technical user should easily understand the applications and the desktop interface used.

Nowadays, this can be done easily thanks to the availability of different kinds of software for the Linux system. But the biggest problem is changing the mental outlook of the employee. "The most important task for both the system